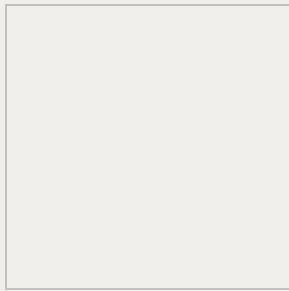


ON TECHNIQUE

Beethoven's pianos

The pianoforte evolved significantly during Beethoven's lifetime. He began performing on five-octave pianos (which were different from modern pianos that span over seven octaves). These wood-framed instruments were delicate and lacked power and durability; they often broke under the stress of Beethoven's muscular high-octane playing. In 1803, he adopted an Erard piano because he admired the effects achieved by its "una corda" soft pedal. Later in Beethoven's life, pianos were made that were closer to his ideal, such as the six-and-a-half octave Broadwood sent to him from England by Thomas Broadwood, head of the company, in 1818. His last works exploited the full range of tone and pitch that such an instrument allows.



BEETHOVEN'S BROADWOOD FORTEPIANO

Ludwig van Beethoven was born in 1770 in Bonn, Germany, then part of the Holy Roman Empire. His family was of Flemish origin—hence the “van” in his name. His father, Johann van Beethoven, was a chorister at the court of the archbishop elector of Cologne in Bonn, where Ludwig's grandfather had been musical director before him. Ludwig's talent was recognized and encouraged from an early age, his father imposing a draconian routine of lessons and practice. The young Ludwig excelled at the keyboard and performed in court music-